



Define

Scene Description

Two students sit side by side in a classroom. They talk directly into the camera.

Transcript

00:00 (INTRODUCTION PLAYS)
00:05 CHRISTINA: Textual evidence. REBECCA: This is a biggie.
00:08 CHRISTINA: That's because most texts require readers
00:10 to interpret the text evidence to understand the intent, meaning or context.
00:16 Every detail in a text can be a clue to its intent, meaning or context.
00:26 REBECCA: So, by detail you mean the words an author chooses?
00:29 CHRISTINA: From word choice all the way up to a major event.
00:31 All of it can be used to find meaning.
00:33 REBECCA: Sometimes the evidence is right on the surface.
00:35 We call this explicit evidence.
00:37 Explicit evidence is directly stated in the text.
00:47 CHRISTINA: Other times you've got to infer the evidence from the details.
00:50 Inferences can support analyses as powerfully as explicitly stated evidence.
01:02 REBECCA: But not all evidence is created equal.
01:04 CHRISTINA: Ahh, that's true.
01:05 You've got to analyze the details to make sure the inference is valid.
01:08 Not all textual evidence has weight.
01:10 Examine all the evidence.
01:18 REBECCA: Here are a few ways to help you do that.
01:20 Look for a series of facts or events in a text that are related.
01:29 CHRISTINA: Think about any prior knowledge related to these facts or events.
01:38 REBECCA: Once you've identified some solid evidence,
01:41 you can make inferences by looking at several aspects of an informational text.
01:45 CHRISTINA: Or by examining characters, setting and plot events in a literary work.
01:49 REBECCA: Remember, without textual evidence, you can't sell your ideas.
01:52 CHRISTINA: Textual evidence: don't leave home without it.

01:55 REBECCA: Really? CHRISTINA: What? It's catchy.

01:58 REBECCA: Let's summarize.

Any time you're explaining something about a text, you need to cite, or point out, textual evidence to support your ideas. Textual evidence may be a word, phrase, sentence, or paragraph that led you to make an inference or draw a conclusion. When you cite textual evidence, someone else can look back at a particular part of a text you read and understand how you came to your inferences or conclusions.

When you make inferences while reading or analyzing a text, you use the text and your own background knowledge to make logical guesses about what is not directly stated by the author. When you are explaining these inferences to someone else, it is important that you use textual evidence to show how and why you analyzed a text in the way that you did.

For example, an analysis of Robert Frost's poem "The Road Not Taken," in which the speaker describes coming to a fork on a forest path and having to choose which one to take, might state:

The difficulty of making choices is an important theme of Frost's poem.

The same analysis is strengthened by going on to cite textual evidence:

Frost establishes this theme in the first few lines. "Two roads diverged in a yellow wood," the speaker begins, "and sorry I could not travel both / and be one traveler, / long I stood . . ." Immediately, we see that the speaker is faced with a tough choice: which way to go.

Whether you're making inferences from a short passage or drawing conclusions based on an entire text, textual evidence is the most important tool for helping you explain your ideas.